Learning How to Walk

By Jason Sheets

WHITNEY: **(Pg 141-145)** All I remember from the incident are five still-frames, mentally stored as black and white images.

Frame # 1: Tony is driving down the road. He spills part of his Taco Bell burrito on his new shirt. I reprimand him. We laugh.

Frame #2: A loud crash. Darkness beyond anything I've ever seen before. It's like I'm miles back into a cave, only darker.

Frame #3: My mother tells me she's glad to see me wake up. She is arranging flowers in the room. She tells me to rest.

Frame #4: My mother tells me I'll be OK, but begins to cry when she states that Tony is not as fortunate. A feeling of death enters my heart.

Frame #5: My friend Tricia tells me that Tony did not die, but can no longer walk. ***He'll need your strength,*** she says. I say I will do whatever I can to help.

That is all I can remember from the incident that changed my life forever. I wish I knew more. I wish the images were at least in color.

INTRODUCTION

When life takes an unexpected turn and someone you love becomes disabled, the challenges faced by both people in the relationship can be overwhelming. In this selection, a young couple are involved in a horrible car accident and are now faced with a future that looks dramatically different from the one they had envisioned. Can Tony learn how to walk again, or will Whitney learn how to walk away?

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WHITNEY: Tony and I met when I was 18 and he was 21. Ironically, because of my AP credit and his momentary lapses of reason, we were both sophomores. I'd never dated much. People

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asked me -- that wasn't the problem. The problem was me: I noticed things. My mother had divorced when I was eight, and she told me to watch out for men. Never settle, she told me. And you could bet I listened to my mother.

But Tony was different. lt took him three months, four sly winks, and a blatantly written note from Tricia to make him finally ask me out. I suppose people marveled at his lack of focus, his carefree nature. I saw it as indelible charm.

Everything interested him. l absolutely detest the "I am a sponge" analogy that so many others overuse, but Tony really was. He soaked up the nuances of movies, of relationships, of me. By the time my 19th birthday rolled around, it was clear: I planned on falling in love once in a lifetime, and Tony would be that one time.

I would like to say that the day of the accident somehow had special connotations to me. Perhaps I'd had an eerie feeling. Perhaps we'd just said we'd always go everywhere together. Perhaps we'd had some moment that defined the day. But there was no real irony to the events. We were riding in the car on the way to my hometown, a truck veered past the median, and then the darkness. It took me 3 days before I could finally see Tony. He was wrapped in countless bandages, but that scene-stealing smile was still there. ***I'm glad you 're OK,*** he said. ***You too,*** I replied before I realized what I was saying. Tony just looked at me with adoration: ***At least I have you,*** he responded.

Unbeknownst to most of the population, I believe doctors have to take a class in medical school that teaches them how to properly double-speak. It took me three more days before I could finally get the man to say that, yes, his brain is fine, but no, he'd never do the two-step with me again. It was only after I cleared the double-speak that the reality of what was happening really kick[ed] in. My life became a series of daily rituals. At nine o' clock I would start my journey to the hospital. If there was one thing I was leery of, it was hospitals. I used to find excuses to keep me from going. The truth was I couldn't stand the smell. The attitude. The feeling of unsettled completion of life that occurred every day. Now, my fear of hospitals and my love for Tony has been unbearably linked. When I think of Tony, l imagine the smell of hospitals. l imagine death. I

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wanted to vomit. Sometimes, I did.

But of course, the doctor is wrong. Tony will walk. He'll walk. Of course he will. It happens all the time in the movies. Doctor says: "I'm sorry, there's just no hope." Patient: "But I can if I try hard enough." Three months later he walks. He does. It happens in the movies. And what are movies? A reflection of real life. Right?

So now I find myself in Tony's house. I've dropped out of school, I have all my calls and mail forwarded. People refer to me as "Nurse Whitney." It was cute for a while. Now I find the title impeccably accurate. The only real difference is that after I wash his face, or feed him or bathe him, he tells me he loves me and I return the feelings. When most nurses get off work, they would go home. We stay up and watch television together and discuss our future. He wants to marry me. He tells me: ***We can still have the fairy tale***. I say, ***Of course we can sweetheart I always said I'd only fall in love one time and you are the one I love***. He follows this by saying I've been the best and that he' lucky to have someone who's willing to make the sacrifice. After he says that I feel strangely worse.

I tell Tony everything. Everything, but my dreams. For the first few months, I dreamt that he'd walk again. Now, I dream of leaving. I dream of running away from all my family and friends who would tell me I was being selfish, and I would spend the rest of my life on some lonely beach reading.

I dream he will say: ***Whitney, I don't love you anymore. Please go***. I dream it. And I never tell anyone. Ever.

I figure the equation and try to re-figure it for a different answer. I never get one. I've [even] started making a list of the ways I could leave. Just in case one could actually be plausible.

1.) I could say I can't afford to stay.
2.) I could say I found someone else.
3.) I could say it's not right of me to dominate his time.
4.) I could say there was a doctor in India who's supposed to have a cure. I'll go find out.

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5.) I could kill myself for thinking these things about the man I love.

6.) I could say I'm not worthy of him because of my evil thoughts -- That one could be plausible.

When I tell him I'm leaving, he does not look shocked, or stunned, or even surprised. He merely says ***OK,*** and then I feel ten times worse. For months, I'd pictured this traumatic scene where I announce my intentions and he begs and pleads with me to stay. He offers me the world and I walk away. Instead, he says ***OK.***

OK, so now I have to explain myself. See, my mother always told me to never settle and always wait for the fairy tale. And you were the fairy tale, Tony! You were my prince that was set to sweep me off my feet and never look back. You were everything. The looks. The smile. The wit. The "sponge" of life that soaked up everything that it has to offer. You were it. You were it. But, see Tony, princes walk. They pick me up and carry me over the threshold on our wedding day. They play football with our children. They go for late night jogs with me when the rest of the world is driving me nuts. They do it all, Tony. That's the fairy tale. That's my fairy tale.

Tony now has a tear running down his cheek and I say to myself ***are you happy now***? Is this the way it's supposed to play out? Is this the way the movie ends?

He says: ***I wish you all the best. If you need me, you know where I'll be.***

I don't know if he's trying to be funny or vindictive, so I leave. I cry.

Life is a series of trades. You give something to get something. Fifty cents: a Pepsi. A compliment: a promotion. I made the biggest trade of all. I traded love for freedom. And now I'm left to ask: ***Did I make the right choice?*** And I like to think I can find the answer, but I can't. All I can think is that in the fairy tales, you get both. In the fairy tale, you get everything.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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